

Ministry Snapshot at a Glance

Pastor Enoch Liao · Boston Chinese Evangelical Church (BCEC) · Boston, Massachusetts

CCCOWE 2026 Explore360 · "The Evolving Chinese Church Around the Globe"

Who's speaking. In the first generation of his family born in the US — parents born in China, raised in Taiwan, arriving as graduate students (the post-1965 wave). Lead English pastor at BCEC (Chinatown roots, founded 1965, now with a suburban campus), 25+ years in ministry, at BCEC since 2001. Contributor to *Letter to the Asian American Church*; active in the Chinese Heritage Church Collaborative. Bert Han, Billy Lo, and Enoch Liao — each 25+ years in the pulpit — are the three cases in his doctoral study of healthy pastoral longevity in the Chinese heritage church.

▪ Who Are the People? Four waves, one roof.

The Chinese heritage church in America is over 150 years old, and the waves are still arriving:

- **1st wave — Gold Rush (late 1800s):** railroad builders and Chinatown founders who stayed when the 1882 Exclusion Act slammed the door. Their descendants: today's 3rd-, 4th-, even 5th-generation Chinese Americans.
- **2nd wave — post-1965 (Hart-Celler):** university-educated graduate students from Taiwan and the mainland. Enoch's family.
- **3rd wave — Hong Kong (around the 1997 handover):** a Cantonese, Hong Kong-formed church culture, arriving into an ecosystem already shaped by two prior waves.
- **4th wave — mainland students (mid-2000s on):** often here for a season, planning to return. They know it.

All four sit under one roof — a wealthy mainland student bound for Shanghai near a 4th-generation Chinese American who has never been to China. Not a problem to solve: the texture of the community he has been given.

▪ Was There a Silent Exodus?

The 1996 "silent exodus" story — the immigrant church loses its children — was **narrated far more than it was measured**. Measured, its strongest form does not hold:

- **Two-thirds actually stayed.** "There does not appear to be a mass exodus" (Park and Tom, analyzing Pew's 2012 Asian American survey).
- **Most who left joined "the nones," like all of America** — a national tide, not a Chinese heritage church peculiarity.
- **We mostly hear from the churches that are struggling.** Quiet retention writes no articles.
- **Those who stayed go to church MORE than white Protestants** (Chen and Park, 2019). More committed, not lukewarm — largely forming their own congregations.

Sources: Chen and Park, *JSSR* 2019; Park and Tom, *AAPI Voices* 2014. *The Chinese-specific dropout rate remains undocumented — not disproven.*

▪ The Reveal: how many generations are in your church?

Not first-second-third. In the US the ladder runs to **fourth and fifth**. "My adult kids are fourth and fifth generation. Fourth on my side, fifth on my wife's." These are the people the exodus narrative says should not exist.

Two questions for leaders: Do we assume every church is like our church? Do we seek out only others who share our struggle, or also those further down the road?

If there was no exodus, what now? Look beyond churches whose experience differs from yours; ask what theology and assumptions need reconsidering; reconsider a biblical definition of diversity. Enoch's "diversity of diversities": generational, linguistic, cultural, political, national, socioeconomic, ethnic and racial — *the typical US Chinese heritage church may be more diverse than a typical white American megachurch.*

▪ Many Variables. One Sovereign God.

God sovereignly uses many factors to shape each local Chinese heritage church, among them: **immigration patterns · socioeconomic status · size and numbers · racialization · the strength of the wider evangelical church.**

The Chinese Heritage Church Collaborative — the bet that these churches can be strengthened from within: 2019 Pastors Colloquium (Boston) · 2020 Online · 2023 First National Gathering (Houston) · 2024 Two Regional Gatherings · 2025 National Gathering · 2026 Two Regional Gatherings · **2027 National Gathering / Ministers Collective (tentative: Chicagoland, May 2027).**